

Bernini

A devout Roman Catholic, Gian Lorenzo Bernini (1598–1680) was an architect, painter, playwright, and costume and theatre designer, but predominantly the inventor of Baroque sculpture. Inspired by the notion of exalting God, he expressed the grandeur of the Baroque with extravagant theatricality, detail, sensitive interpretations of textures and portrayals of movement. His dynamic figures express palpable emotions, and his portraits also depict fleeting facial expressions with acute realism. He had the unique ability to make cold, hard marble look soft and warm.

During his long career, Bernini worked under successive popes and became a leading architect, working on St Peter's Basilica. His dramatic colonnade transformed the front courtyard of Rome's cathedral, and he was also responsible for town-planning schemes and instigated the extravagant Baroque fountains in several Roman piazzas. His reputation declined temporarily, after his bell towers for St Peter's began cracking in 1641, yet he is still acknowledged as the last of Italy's comprehensive geniuses.



Bernini, *Ecstasy of Saint Teresa*, 1647–52